

01-09-2024 MCS Board Meeting

Meeting Metadata	Details
Video Recording	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=YX7zJSLW8Oo
Publication Date	2024-01-10T11:38:57Z
Target Category	mcs

Notice: This report is provided by the [Muncie Policy Memo](#) as a public service. This summary is generated automatically using artificial intelligence from public video transcripts, both of which are prone to error. The report is intended to provide an overview of meeting business and an aid to accessing detailed information from the video recording. When accuracy is critical, please refer to the official video recording or approved minutes.

Muncie Community Schools Board of School Trustees

Meeting Summary Report

Meeting Date: January 2024 (Exact date not explicitly stated in transcript, though references are made to January 2024 and Martin Luther King Jr. weekend events on Saturday/Monday)

Location: Central's Auditorium / Boardroom (Muncie, Indiana)

1. Meeting Identification & Attendance

- **Call to Order & Spoken Details:** The regular meeting was called to order by Board President Mr. Williams. The meeting opened with the Pledge of Allegiance led by members and attendees.
- **Attendance:**
 - **Present:** Dr. O'Neal, Mrs. Farence Griffin, Mr. Lee, Mr. Irvan.
 - **Absent:** Mr. Heeker (noted as being in Australia).
 - **Presiding Officer:** Mr. Williams (Board President).

2. Preliminary & Procedural Business

- **Ceremonial Openings:**
 - The board led attendees in the Pledge of Allegiance [00:05:35](#).

- **Recognition of Northside Esports:** The board recognized the Northside Middle School "Northside Titans" 2023 Rocket League Indiana State Champions and their coach, Mr. Tony Harter, along with team members (Graham Bous, Finn Panton, Caleb Vanderbilt [Captain], Colton Closer, Ethan Showalter, Parker Sadler, and support mascot Uno Tra) 00:06:37. Representatives from Ball State University's esports program were also introduced and congratulated 00:17:26.
 - **New Staff Introductions:** New hires including Riley Foster and Megan Slapa (Longfellow) were introduced to the board 00:31:05.
 - **Approval of Minutes:** Approved via the consent agenda.
-

3. Substantive Business & Board Action

- 00:30:10 **Consent Agenda (Minutes, Personnel, Donations, & New Hires)**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Administration / Mr. Williams.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** The board highlighted generous community donations during the holiday season, specifically recognizing Maxwell Barber Shop for a generous donation to the backpack program.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote 00:32:45.
- 00:29:56 **2023 Financial Report & End-of-Year Summary**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Mr. Dome (Business Manager).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Mr. Dome presented the 12-month actual financial results for 2023. Key highlights included:
 - State basic grant totaled \$44.3 million (up nearly \$2 million from the prior year).
 - Total payroll reached slightly over \$33 million.
 - Long-term debt payments totaled over \$12 million for the year (including a final payment of over \$3.5 million for the 2014 General Obligation bonds, retiring them).
 - Total checkbook balance across all funds was \$32.9 million (up significantly from \$1.1 million in December 2018).
 - Education fund ending balance stood at over \$15.3 million.
 - State loan balance was reduced to \$9.9 million.
 - Rainy Day fund balance grew to over \$7.7 million.
 - Local property tax collections totaled \$11.8 million (representing 52% of the local levy).
 - Earned interest income reached a record \$745,000 for 2023.
 - Discussion ensued regarding ongoing operational fund pressures driven by property tax caps.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote 04:43:21 (following financial presentation and board discussion).
- 00:44:31 **Education to Operations Fund Transfers**

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Mr. Dome (Business Manager).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Annual request for blanket approval to transfer up to 15% of total education fund revenue into the operation fund as permitted by state statute. Mr. Dome noted that in the prior year, the district transferred 14% (\$6.5 million).
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote [00:46:17](#).
 - **00:46:26 Early Literacy Policy & Achievement Grant Statement**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Dr. Bell.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Dr. Bell presented the adoption of the Early Literacy Achievement Grant policy for 2024, established via state legislation (HEA 1001). The grant rewards schools for improving foundational reading skills (K-3, including Pre-K). The district created a two-tier distribution structure: Tier 1 for certified teachers, master teachers, interventionists, resource teachers, and full-time speech-language pathologists; Tier 2 for instructional assistants and preschool lead teachers. Muncie received favorable funding allocations due to strong student growth scores and a poverty factor.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote [00:50:59](#).
 - **00:53:31 Property and Casualty Insurance Renewal**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Mr. Dome.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Presented the annual Property and Casualty insurance renewal binder, which showed an unexpected and substantial premium increase of \$321,000. Board members expressed deep concern over the massive hike, discussing national market trends (wildfires, inflation, replacement values versus assessed values), loss history (including historical tornado damage reimbursements), and potential future alternatives like co-ops or self-insurance. Administration noted that coverage must remain active while they continue exploring secondary quotes and Plan B options.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote [01:11:15](#).
 - **01:11:21 Revised and Retired Policy Updates**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Administration / Board Counsel.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Final monthly reading of policy updates, revisions, and retirements aligned with NEOLA numbering systems and current state statutes.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote [01:12:18](#).
-

4. Board of Finance Annual Meeting

- **01:12:58 Opening of Board of Finance & Election of Officers**
 - The regular meeting temporarily transitioned into the annual Board of Finance meeting.
 - **Officers Appointed:** Mrs. Farence Griffin appointed as Board of Finance President; Mr. Irvan appointed as Board of Finance Secretary. Approved by Voice Vote

01:13:43.

- **01:14:15 Board of Finance Annual Report**

- **Presenter:** Mr. Dome.
 - **Deliberation Summary:**
 - Earned interest income for 2023 reached \$745,000.
 - Overall long-term debt decreased from \$38.5 million in 2018 down to \$26.2 million at the end of 2023 (a reduction of \$12.3 million).
 - Rainy Day fund balance stood at \$7.7 million.
 - Overall tax rate remained flat at \$1.20.
 - Board members requested a comprehensive, high-level summary report combining financial health trends, debt reduction, and facility improvements to present at upcoming university and community presentations.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Accepted as presented by Voice Vote [01:23:26](#).
 - **Adjournment of Finance Meeting:** Adjourned by Voice Vote [01:23:55](#).
-

5. Open Public Comment / Citizen Forum

- *Note: No open public comment period or citizen forum speakers were recorded during this portion of the transcript.*
-

6. Administrative Updates & Adjournment

- **Staff / Board Announcements:**
 - **Dr. Kowalski (CEO Update):**
 - Announced that three built-in snow days have been established on the calendar (April 12, April 26, and May 10), serving as traditional snow days off for students and teachers if not utilized.
 - Noted a state grant received to cover Pre-K costs for employees starting next year.
 - Highlighted a grant received in collaboration with the courts (modelled after Porter County) to address chronic absenteeism via a hearing officer and action plans.
 - Announced that West View's renovation is complete, with classrooms ready and a formal kickoff ceremony planned for early February.
 - Reminded the community of the MLK Youth Citizenship Awards at Central's Auditorium on Saturday at 10:00 AM, and the MLK Jr. Community Breakfast on Monday at 9:00 AM at the Ball State University Student Center.
 - **Adjournment:** The meeting was officially adjourned following the conclusion of the Board of Finance business.
-

Muncie Policy Memo Civic Monitoring Automated Pipeline. Report generated on 2026-10-04 09:21:08 using model gemini-3.5-flash-lite.